

Fact-Checker Training

Yellow Level: I'm Ready for a Challenge

Name: _____ Date: _____

The Big Idea

Optical illusions prove that our eyes and brains can be fooled—even when we're paying attention! Throughout history, people have used this to deceive others: from Victorian "ghost photographers" who tricked grieving families, to modern "deepfake" videos that put fake words in real people's mouths. The good news? You can learn to protect yourself.

The 5 Fact-Checker Rules

1. **STOP** before you share — Don't spread information just because it's exciting
2. **CHECK** the source — Who created this? Are they trustworthy?
3. **SEARCH** for more — Can you find this from other reliable sources?
4. **ASK** an adult — When in doubt, check with someone you trust
5. **TRUST YOUR GUT** — If it seems too good (or too weird) to be true, investigate more

Apply the Rules

For each scenario, write which rule(s) you would use AND explain why:

Scenario 1: A post says your favorite celebrity is coming to your town this weekend, but you've never heard of the website sharing it.

Rules I'd use: _____

Why:

Scenario 2: Your friend shows you a video of a politician saying something really mean. The video looks real.

Rules I'd use: _____

Why:

Scenario 3: You see a post saying a new video game gives you a virus. You want to warn your friends.

Rules I'd use: _____

Why:

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Create Your Own Scenario

Write a situation where someone might need to use the Fact-Checker Rules:

Which rules would help? Why?



Mini Museum Connection

The Mini Museum displays Victorian optical illusion cards and a stereoscope from 1904. These devices amazed people who didn't understand how they worked. Spirit photographers used similar tricks to create "ghost photos" and charged grieving families money. Understanding the trick = power to protect yourself!

Visit: minimuseumproject.com/exhibitions/seeing-is-deceiving

Reflection Questions

1. Why do you think people believed the fake "ghost photos" were real back in the 1860s?

2. What makes it harder to spot fakes today compared to back then?

Share with Your Family!

Family Discussion: Ask your family about a time they saw something online that turned out to be false. How did they figure out it wasn't true?

Family Challenge: Together, find a news story and practice using the Fact-Checker Rules. Can you verify if it's true?